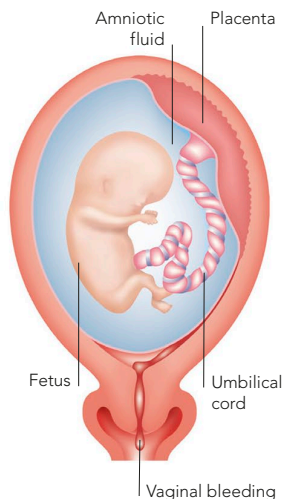


MISCARRIAGE

Miscarriage, or spontaneous abortion, is the unintended end of a pregnancy before week 24. It is very common, occurring in 25 per cent of all pregnancies. Most miscarriages occur in the first 14 weeks of pregnancy; over half of them are due to a genetic or fetal abnormality. Later miscarriages have various causes, ranging from physical problems with the cervix or uterus to severe infection. Smoking, alcohol, or drug abuse may also be factors. If three or more occur consecutively, it is known as recurrent miscarriage.

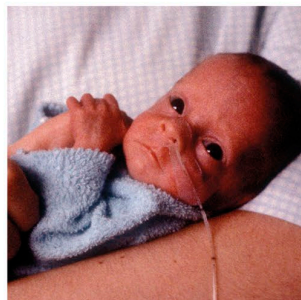


THREATENED MISCARRIAGE

The fetus remains alive and the cervix is closed, although there is some blood loss. It may proceed to full miscarriage, when the fetus dies, or a successful birth.

PRETERM LABOUR

Most pregnancies last for about 40 weeks, but delivery during the final three weeks is considered to be full term. Labour that occurs before 37 weeks is known as preterm and results in a premature baby. Premature labour rarely causes maternal problems, but the earlier the birth, the greater the problems encountered by the baby. The cause is not always known, but multiple births, urinary tract infection, and fetal abnormalities are known to be trigger factors. Sometimes, premature labour can be halted or delayed, giving the baby more time in the womb.

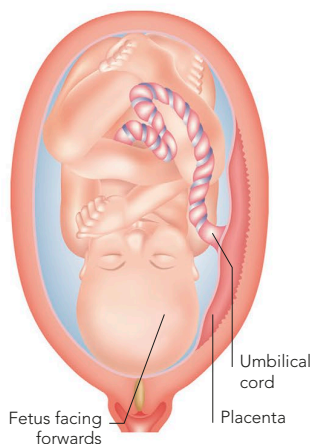


PREMATURE BABY

This premature baby is being fed through a nasogastric tube because his sucking reflex has yet to develop and his swallowing ability is poor. Other features are his tiny size, wrinkled and yellow skin, and disproportionately large eyes.

ABNORMAL PRESENTATION

Eighty per cent of babies adopt the normal delivery position for birth, with the head down and facing towards the mother's back. The baby usually achieves this position by about week 36. Other babies are in a position that may cause problems during labour. Breech (see p.266) and occipitoposterior positions (see right) are the most common of these abnormal presentations. In a breech birth, the baby's buttocks present first. Some presentations may allow the umbilical cord to drop through the birth canal and cause fetal distress. The cervix and vagina are more vulnerable to tears if the presentation is abnormal.



OCCIPITOPOSTERIOR POSITION

Although the baby's head is facing down, as is normal, the baby is turned 180° towards the front, instead of facing the mother's back.